Force One. “Mr. President, you do not have a cold. Something strange is happening,” he said to Kennedy when they were alone. “The minute you get back in Washington, you are going to find out what it is,” responded Kennedy. “And when you do, grab your balls.”[1]

Robert Kennedy later recalled that he had phoned his brother before 10:00 a.m. to request his return to Washington. He believed that the discussions held by Kennedy aides with and without the president on October 16 had run their course, and the president had to make his final decision on which way to go with regard to Cuba. “It was now up to one single man,” wrote Bobby. “No committee was going to make this decision.” Upon receiving his brother’s call, John Kennedy rushed back to Washington. Unbeknownst to him, he was flying right into the zone now covered by the Soviet missiles in Cuba. As his plane was in the air, the first Soviet R-12 medium-range missiles were being made fully operational near Sagua la Grande in western Cuba.[2]

Colonel Ivan Sidorov and his men of the 79th Missile Regiment celebrated their first victory with a small rally. “We will defend Cuba as our Motherland,” read a slogan hanging over the makeshift podium made of a few sacks of soil brought from the Soviet Union. Next to the podium they placed a red-and-white-striped pole symbolizing a Soviet border post. The speeches were met with applause, gunfire, and slogans in Russian and Spanish: *Rodina ili smert’—Patria o muerte*. “Motherland or death.” The Soviet rocket men had just found a new motherland. They were prepared to die for it and spread death in the process. Given the R-12’s operational range of 2,080 kilometers, Sidorov’s missiles would have fallen short of Chicago (2,233 kilometers away) but could easily have reached the DC area, only 1,812 kilometers away, where the president’s plane would land in the early afternoon.[3]

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THE PRESIDENT HAD LEFT WASHINGTON ON THE MORNING OF Friday, October 19. He had spent the previous day in and out of sessions with his advisers, brainstorming the Cuban problem. They dealt with a new batch of